

Paid Research & Expert Side-Income

MARKET VIEW · JULY 2026

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Method: 75-agent research workflow — 10 audit agents re-checking the July report claim by claim, 12 parallel finders, adversarial verification of the top 24 findings by two independent refuters each, a completeness critic, and 4 gap-fill researchers. 1,411 tool calls · 119 unique opportunities · all figures fetched live 31 July 2026 unless dated otherwise.

Profile modelled: 43, Tonbridge (40 min to London Bridge) · e-commerce SME owner ~£80k/yr across eBay/Amazon/BrickLink/Vinted · senior Python/TypeScript developer with production LLM-agent experience · 20 yrs Accenture delivery · strong personal-finance literacy · 10+ hrs/week · 1-hour travel radius, further if lucrative.

1 · The headline

Three things changed the picture versus the July report.

The premium qual-research tier is roughly half what we thought. July's plan leaned on "specialist B2B/finance briefs pay £150–£300 per session." Two independent verifiers killed it against live boards on 31 July: Take Part in Research currently shows £45 for a 90-minute banking focus group and £125 for a 1–2 week business-banking diary study — not per session. Angelfish publishes £50–£65 for a generic 60-minute group. The £150–£475 briefs exist but are occasional, not the standard rate for a business owner. Tier 1 is a £150–£300/month channel, not the £300–£800 it looked like.

The best £/hour in the entire study isn't research at all — it's bank-account switching. ~£1,745 sits on the table right now across eight live offers, at roughly £100+/hour of admin, and it is **tax-free** (HMRC SP4/1997). Nothing in the paid-research world comes close on effort-adjusted, tax-adjusted return. It was completely absent from the July report because the brief never asked about cash arbitrage.

A compliance fact that neither report knew: your VAT headroom is only ~£10k. That means *which entity* an expert network contracts you through determines whether the work threatens VAT registration across the whole LEGO business. Get it wrong and it's a five-figure mistake that dwarfs the side income. (The other 2026 change — Making Tax Digital for Income Tax, first quarterly update due 7 August — is already filed, so what remains there is the ongoing cadence and how to structure a second trade.)

2 · Audit of the July report

Ten load-bearing claims re-verified against primary sources. **Seven confirmed, three changed.** Nothing was fabricated, but three items would mislead if republished as-is.

Claim	Verdict	What's true now
MRS register lists exactly six recruitment agencies	CONFIRMED	Bright Research, FieldMouse, People for Research, Roots Research, Saros, The Insights Desk — exact match, no changes
People for Research ~£1/min, £40–£100+/hr, ~3-day payout	CONFIRMED	Verbatim on their site; 3-day clock starts after client confirms attendance
Saros £40–£100/session, ~2 studies/yr, ~1 week payment	CONFIRMED	Official wording is "from £40"; in-person sessions usually paid cash on the day
User Interviews: 1–2 studies per 6 months, AI screener answers penalised	CONFIRMED	Still current
Mercor ~\$90/hr, Trustpilot 4.4, weekly pay, droughts and terminations	CONFIRMED	Now more precise: \$75–\$200/hr for expert SWE evals, weekly Wednesday payouts via Stripe/Wise
UserTesting decline: \$10/20-min, ~5–8% acceptance, earnings £20–100/mo	CONFIRMED	Live Conversations at \$30/30min, \$60/60min, \$90–120 specialised remain the only sensible target
Tax: incentives taxable, not PAYE earnings; £1,000 trading allowance unusable	CONFIRMED	EIM71105 verified verbatim; allowance still a single cross-trade election that would cost you HB's expense deductions
Respondent: \$95 avg, \$150–250 focus groups, ~\$200/hr developers	CHANGED	Now \$75 average payout , 45-min typical session. Most sessions \$50–\$250; senior B2B \$400+. Developer guidance is \$150 remote / \$300 in-person , not \$200/hr. PayPal was removed in May 2025 — payouts are Tremendous gift cards only , a real drawback for UK participants. The 5% fee is unchanged.
Expert networks: \$100–250/hr ICs; AlphaSights, Third Bridge, Dialectica London-HQ	CHANGED	Rates hold (Woozle Dec 2025, n=1,368: most common band \$100–199/call). Dialectica is Athens-headquartered , not London — it has a London office. AlphaSights and Third Bridge are correctly London-HQ. Survey pay is better than stated: \$50–\$100 , not \$40–\$80.
Outlier: active Rogowicz lawsuit, rates \$28–35 → \$18–22/hr	CHANGED	The suit settled for \$12.5M (consolidated as McKinney et al. v. Scale AI; final approval hearing 30 Oct 2026, California residents only). F BBB rating confirmed. Real spread is wider and worse than stated: \$12–28/hr generalist, \$35–60 for credentialed STEM/coding . Deactivations confirmed and hardened — a 28 Apr 2026 wave stated "We will not consider further appeals."

Also refuted during the sweep (these were not in the July report but were proposed by finders and killed before reaching you):

- **Call For Participants is dead.** The study aggregator returns 404 with "This service is no longer active", shutdown notice dated 8 Jan 2026.
- **Indiefield's panel cannot be joined.** Their page states membership is "strictly invitation only... Nobody signs up." The deliberative-workshop route via public registers doesn't exist as described.
- **NewtonX's rate figures** trace to a single blog post dated 30 September 2021 being passed around as current.
- **UCL's "£80–£200, average £140" fMRI figure** comes from a March 2018 recruitment ad — eight years stale.
- **An "expert network market \$3bn → \$4.86bn in 2026" statistic** was misattributed and internally inconsistent (that would be 62% growth against a cited 12–16% rate). The real figure: ~\$3bn now, ~16% annual growth.

3 • The ranked map

Ranked by effective £/hour × realistic volume × certainty, net of tax. Percentages of your time should follow this order.

Tier A — highest return, start here

1 • Current-account switching — ~£1,745 live, tax-free, ~£100+/hr The best effort-adjusted return in the study, and it needs no new skills. Per MoneySavingExpert (28 Jul 2026): HSBC £220, Barclays £200 + Tesco fuel cashback, NatWest £200 + £25×3, First Direct £175, Nationwide £175, Bank of Scotland £175, Co-op £125 + £25×3. Roughly 1–2 hours of admin per switch. **Deadlines matter: Bank of Scotland by 4 Aug, Barclays initiate by 27 Aug.** Open two or three free donor accounts (Starling/Monzo secondary), attach two small direct debits to each, and switch *donors* — never your main HSBC account. Realistic £800–£1,400 in year one, tapering as one-per-bank exclusions bite. Avoid all switching for six months before any mortgage application.

2 • Expert networks — £150–£250/hr, genuinely scarce profile Your marketplace-operator angle is the real asset here, not "software developer." A profitable seller across Vinted, eBay, Amazon *and* BrickLink simultaneously is exactly the ground-truth voice PE and hedge-fund clients buy when underwriting resale-sector deals — and Woozle's 2025 data found 31% of expert calls involve people who admit they weren't fully qualified, meaning genuinely qualified operators are undersupplied.

Self-serve registration (do these first): **GLG** (open onboarding, highest raw project flow, pays per-minute), **Third Bridge** (London, strongest thematic fit, \$250–500/hr typical), **proSapient** (London, best-rated mid-tier), **Office Hours** (set own rate, 5% + 2.9% fees, pays 200+ countries). Register-interest only:

AlphaSights (explicitly "does not operate as a sign-up network"), **Guidepoint** (note:

guidepoint.com/become-an-advisor now 404s — use

new.guidepointglobaladvisors.com/apply/becomeanadvisor), **Dialectica** (recruits via LinkedIn scraping, so optimise your headline).

Set \$200–250/hr for the marketplace persona and \$300/hr for the AI-practitioner persona. Rates above ~\$400 measurably reduce selection for an unrated first-timer; raise 25–50% after three to five rated calls. Realistic 2–4 calls/month once profiled = **£300–£900/month, lumpy and event-driven**, £150–£250 in quiet quarters.

3 • Wynter — best raw £/hour of anything found B2B message testing: 2–10 minute asynchronous reviews of SaaS landing pages. As founder of an e-commerce business you land in the **senior-leadership band at \$25–\$50 per test**, and e-commerce is a named priority sector. That's £100–£300/hour equivalent. Volume is the constraint — they state "at least two invitations per month" for matching profiles. **£30–£80/month for under an hour of total effort.** Ten-minute signup; there is no reason not to.

4 • Clinical studies — the biggest single cheques, and London Bridge is 40 minutes away This layer was entirely absent from July's report and it's the largest per-event money available to you.

- **Richmond Pharmacology / Trials4us** — 1a Newcomen Street, London Bridge. Direct Southeastern train, ~40 min. Live study C25039 pays **up to £2,975** (4-day residential + follow-ups). Headline rate £200/day. Age 18–55 caps apply.
- **HMR / Nucleus Network London** — wider age caps (18–65) and the highest published figures: study 25-012 at **£3,250–£8,500**, study 25-010 at **up to £6,000**. That placebo-vs-active spread is the single biggest variance in London phase-1 pay — ask about it explicitly.

- **FluCamp / hVIVO** — viral challenge studies, **£275/day**, 11–15 days (~£3,000–£4,100 per study). Two features make it unusually good: they pay **£40 and £70 for screening visits even if you're rejected**, and the repeat interval is ~3 months rather than standard phase-1 washout. Quarantine with wifi is oddly compatible with running an online business.
- **The highest-leverage insight in this whole section:** Richmond runs far more *patient* studies than healthy-volunteer ones, and several define "patient" loosely — mildly raised cholesterol or triglycerides qualifies. Those arms cap at **18–70 and pay £2,400–£5,025**, versus healthy arms capping at 18–55 for £2,000–£3,000. **A £30–£60 private lipid panel before you register tells you which pool you're in.**
- **The ceiling:** TOPS (the Over-volunteering Prevention System, run by the HRA) is checked at screening by every UK unit and stops you chaining studies. Plan on 2–3 dosed studies per year across all units combined — **£4k–£12k/yr, lumpy**. Crucially TOPS covers *medicines* trials only; fMRI, sleep and nutrition studies stack on top freely.

Tier B — the volume layer

5 • AI-training contracts — the only thing that absorbs 10 hrs/week Ranked for your CV: **Mercor** first (\$75–\$200/hr for expert software-engineering evals; UK is supported; weekly Wednesday payouts; expect 1–4 weeks to first match), then **DataAnnotation** coding track (advertises \$50–\$100+/hr; the Starter Assessment is **one attempt only** — treat it as a real exam), then **micro1** (\$72/hr average across 295 live listings as of 3 Jul 2026; you set your own rate — \$70–85/hr is credible). **Snorkel** pays \$50–\$100 per accepted artefact but UK eligibility is unconfirmed — the application is the eligibility check. Skip Outlier except as a dormant backup, and skip Handshake (US residency required).

When a contract is live this is **£1,500–£2,000/month at 8–10 hrs/week**. When it isn't, it's zero. Budget for gap months rather than treating it as a base.

6 • Matched betting — £600–£1,000 in the first three months, tax-free Sign-up offers are where the money is and they don't repeat. OddsMonkey bills monthly (£39.99) so you can run the welcome-offer phase for 2–3 months and quit, versus Outplayed's £249.99 annual. Honest steady state after gubbing (~40% of accounts restricted by month 6): **£150–£350/month at 3–5 hrs/week in year one, decaying to £100–£250 in year two**. Tax-free per BIM22017. Treat it as a 6–12 month project, not a permanent line. The new Gambling Commission financial-risk thresholds (announced 7 Jul 2026) trigger at £5,000 net deposits/24h — well above your operating range, so it's friction rather than a blocker.

7 • AI red-teaming bounties — the best skill fit in the study Competition and bounty income, not platform labour, and it maps directly onto what you already build.

- **Gray Swan Arena** — monthly indirect-prompt-injection competitions, **\$20,000 pools** (\$14k leaderboard for top 40, \$6k proportional). July's live challenges are npm scope redirects, malicious plugin installs via poisoned data contracts, silent mail-forward rules — your daily domain. **The real prize is placement, not cash: top 40 finishers are invited into a private paid red-teaming network** with lab and enterprise engagements. Make top-40 the KPI.
- **OpenAI Safety Bug Bounty (Bugcrowd)** — agentic tools, Connectors and MCP: **P1 \$5,500–\$7,500**, P2 \$2,500–\$3,500. Only **7 vulnerabilities rewarded in ~12 months** — extraordinarily low competition for a surface you understand. Use a dedicated test account; safety testing gets accounts banned.
- **Mozilla oDIN** — \$500–\$15,000, and uniquely researcher-friendly: submit a high-level abstract and they tell you within 3 business days whether it's in scope and the likely band, before you write anything up.

Lowest barrier to a first cheque. Target interpreter jailbreaks (medium) and content manipulation (high), not plain guardrail bypasses (low).

- **Google AI VRP** — up to \$20,000 for rogue actions, \$15,000 for data exfiltration, but heavily hunted and duplicate-sensitive.
- **Negative finding worth knowing:** Anthropic's cyber-jailbreak programme (launched Jul 2026, scoped to Claude Fable 5) is explicitly "**a disclosure program, not a bug bounty — we do not offer monetary rewards.**" Their paying programme is the infrastructure one. Don't budget income there, though a strong public finding has historically bought invitations to paid rounds.

Tier C — the steady base

8 • UK qual agencies — register with all of them in one 45-minute sitting: Saros, Angelfish Opinions, Take Part in Research, People for Research, plus the London cluster (Ripple Research £40–£150, Focus Force, Vocal Views, PeopleSight, Plus Four). Each agency's cooling-off clock runs independently, so breadth is the whole strategy — and it's the *honest* strategy, since screener dishonesty gets you blacklisted across networks that share recruiters. Your flexible daytime diary is a genuine edge: weekday daytime slots are the hardest for recruiters to fill. **£150–£300/month.**

9 • Professional research platforms — Respondent and User Interviews (browse-and-apply rather than waiting for invites; UK volume is thinner than US), People for Research for UX (£40–£100+/hr, real GBP, no currency friction), dscout for diary missions (\$50–\$200, and your intro video gates everything). **£100–£400/month combined**, spiky.

10 • Prolific and academic labs — Prolific enforces £6/hr minimum, recommends £9, and pays more for AI/coding prescreeners; install the official Prolific Assistant notifier (third-party notifiers risk bans). London labs are marginal on their own — LSE £13/hr, LBS £10/hr, UCL School of Management (Canary Wharf, Amazon vouchers) — and only pay for themselves if you stack two or three sessions on a day you're already in town. **£50–£150/month.**

Tier D — monetising the LEGO authority directly

Not "research work," but higher-value uses of the same expertise, and the completeness critic was right to flag that July's report treated your collectibles knowledge only as screener-bait.

- **Whatnot UK** — live LEGO auctions. Hosts *are* sellers, so this isn't a job application; it converts existing inventory through a channel with ~11% all-in fees against eBay's, in a UK scene far less saturated than the US. Up to \$2k in first-month seller rewards. **£200–£600/month incremental**, 1–2 evening shows a week.
- **C&T Auctioneers, Kenardington (nr Ashford)** — a **live vacancy** for a Vintage & Collectible Toy specialist, ~35–40 min drive, hybrid working, and they've just launched a Retro Toys department. The parallel role on the same page is advertised as "base wage with commission incentives." Worth an email framing the £80k operation and openness to part-time.
- **Expert witness / valuation** — UK Register of Expert Witnesses accepts an unvetted listing with no prior instructions (£40+VAT registration, £190+VAT annual), and EWI Affiliate membership is £100/yr. Collectibles valuation is unregulated, so credibility rests on demonstrable market knowledge — which you have in data form. Slow burn: 0–3 instructions a year at £500–£2,500 each, but it compounds and pairs with probate work in the dense West Kent solicitor market.
- **Blocks Magazine** — a "what actually happened to last year's retired sets, with sell-through data from a full-time reseller" column is a genuinely differentiated pitch. £100–£200 per feature, low certainty.

Skip these

Mystery shopping is a £100–£300/month overlay at best and only via the premium lane (Ipsos finance/insurance briefs £80–£150, automotive dealership shops, Tern video work) — everything app-based is sub-£10/hr net unless stacked onto journeys you're already making. UserTesting's unmoderated \$10 queue, Centercode/Betabound (volunteers, no cash), ADPList (free-only), Superpeer and Continuum (both defunct), OnFrontiers (US federal focus), Bank of England Citizens' Forum (explicitly unpaid — join for the policymaker access and the FIRE-tool credibility, not the money).

4 • Tax and structure

Making Tax Digital — Q1 filed. **DONE** You're in the first mandated cohort (~£80k turnover against the £50k threshold, mandated from 6 April 2026) and the first quarterly update is done. What's left is the cadence — **7 Nov, 7 Feb, 7 May** — on cumulative year-to-date figures that later updates can correct, and the penalty regime that starts from 2027-28 (one point per late update, £200 at four points). Since you already run a Supabase-backed finance tracker with categorised transactions, a quarterly-totals export mapped to MTD categories would make the remaining three submissions near-automatic — and is itself a credibility artefact for the FIRE-tool product.

VAT — you have about £10k of headroom, and the counterparty's country decides whether work eats into it. A sole trader is one person for VAT: LEGO turnover plus any UK-place-of-supply consultancy aggregates toward the £90,000 rolling threshold. But under VAT Notice 741A's B2B general rule, services supplied to a business customer belonging **outside** the UK are outside the scope of UK VAT and **don't count toward registration turnover**. So GLG (Gerson Lehrman Group Inc) and Guidepoint Global LLC contracting from US entities are free; a UK-incorporated network billing you as a UK supply burns headroom. Check the contracting entity in each agreement footer before signing, and keep a rolling-12-month tab with a UK-supply/outside-scope split and an alert at ~£87k. Registering would put 20% VAT across the whole LEGO retail business — a five-figure annual margin hit that would swamp everything in this report.

Two structural choices that follow from those: 1. Consolidate all fee-based side work into ONE "consultancy and research services" trade. Each self-employment needs its own quarterly updates, so splitting expert calls, consulting and red-teaming into separate trades would multiply submissions for no benefit. **2. Report genuine participant incentives as miscellaneous income** (EIM71105), not trade receipts. That keeps them outside MTD qualifying income, outside VAT turnover, and outside Class 4 NI — roughly a 6% saving. The boundary is fact-based, so keep skill-based work (expert calls, moderated sessions, bounties) in the consultancy trade and only genuine participant payments in miscellaneous.

Also worth knowing: UK digital platform reporting has **no de-minimis exemption for services** — the €2,000/30-sales carve-out applies to goods only. HMRC already receives your Vinted and eBay data. Assume every pound of platform income is visible.

5 • The numbers

Steady state after a 2–3 month ramp, before tax:

Layer	Monthly	Notes
Bank switching	£70–£115	Tax-free; year-one heavy (~£800–£1,400), tapers after
Expert networks	£150–£900	Lumpy, event-driven; 2–4 calls/mo once rated
AI-training contract	£0–£2,000	Binary: all-or-nothing on whether a project is live
UK qual agencies	£150–£300	Revised down from July after the premium-tier refutation
Professional platforms	£100–£400	Respondent, User Interviews, PFR, dscout
Prolific + academic	£50–£150	Background income, desk-adjacent
Matched betting	£150–£350	Tax-free; decays through year two
Clinical studies	£330–£1,000	Really £4k–£12k/yr in 2–3 lumps, not monthly
Red-teaming bounties	£0–£500	Speculative; the private-network invite is the real prize
Whatnot	£200–£600	Business channel, not research income

Honest blended expectation: £700–£1,500/month steady state, with almost the entire spread determined by two binary questions — is an AI-training contract live, and did a clinical study land this quarter.

That's above July's £450–£1,100 estimate, but the *composition* changed more than the total: less from qual agencies than we thought, considerably more from bank switching, clinical studies and AI-training work.

On tax, which matters more than it looks: at your marginal rate (40% plus up to 6% Class 4 on trade profits) taxed layers retain roughly 54–60%. Bank switching and matched betting retain 100%. A tax-free £100 is worth about £180 of consultancy billing — which is precisely why the switching layer, unglamorous as it is, outranks work that sounds far more impressive.

6 • First thirty days

This week (deadline-driven): start Bank of Scotland's switch before 4 Aug. Sign up to Gray Swan Arena — the July competition closes 2 Aug, though past waves stay scorable. Ten minutes each on Wynter and the GOV.UK research panel.

Week 1 (the compounding registrations): GLG, Third Bridge, proSapient and Office Hours — all self-serve, all with keyword-dense profiles built around the *marketplace operator* identity first and the AI practitioner second. Apply to Mercor with a real UK mobile. Register with the four core UK agencies in one sitting. Book a private lipid panel.

Week 2: AlphaSights, Guidepoint and Dialectica register-interest forms. Optimise LinkedIn — Dialectica recruits by scraping it. Respondent and User Interviews profiles with all professional facets filled. Register with Richmond Pharmacology and HMR; ask each about washout policy and the placebo/active pay split. DataAnnotation's Starter Assessment, in a quiet three-hour block, because there are no retakes.

Weeks 3–4: work every screener that arrives with specific 30-word answers. Start whichever AI platform accepted you, capped at ~5 hrs/week until the first payment actually lands. Whatnot seller application. Email C&T Auctioneers. Continue the switching cycle at roughly one a month.

Track everything from day one — platform, date, hours, £, payment date, and next-eligible date per agency. You need it for Self Assessment regardless, it's the only way to know within 60 days which channels

deserve your hours, and the cooling-off tracking is a scheduling problem you're unusually well equipped to solve.

7 • Confidence and caveats

Every figure marked as fetched was pulled from a primary source on 31 July 2026. The 24 highest-confidence findings each faced two independent adversarial verifiers — one testing currency, one testing whether advertised rates survive contact with reality — and five were killed outright, which is the process working.

Where the evidence is thin, it's flagged in place: Quotient Sciences' £8k–£14k long-stay figures come from a single SEO-flavoured article and need verifying directly before you plan around them; Catawiki salary bands and expert-witness hourly rates are market estimates, not published figures; Snorkel's UK eligibility is genuinely unknown until you apply. Reddit was unreachable throughout (the fetcher is blocked), so the r/beermoneyuk cross-check on matched-betting steady-state numbers couldn't be completed — those figures come from independent 2026 analyses rather than community reports.

The largest remaining uncertainty is the same one July identified, now better quantified: expert-network income is the highest-upside and least predictable layer, and nobody's first quarter looks like their fourth.

Companion to `Docs/paid-research-participation-2026-07.md` (the July report this audits) and `Docs/side-income-plan-2026-06.md` (the three-track plan, of which this is an additional independent track).